



Peninsula Market vandalized

The Peninsula Market grocery store, located in Lake Kathryn Village in Wauna, had a break-in on Friday, June 16, at approximately 2:30 a.m. Thieves smashed the bottom of the sliding door, and stole cigarettes and beer, according to store staff. Total estimated damages are \$700. No arrests have been made as of press time. *Photo by Karen Hale*

News briefs

Survey seeks to assess needs of seniors

The realities of “aging in place” on the Key Peninsula are that needed services, programs and facilities are often difficult to locate or do not exist at all. Elders are often forced to move away to find the services they require for daily living. A group of residents are working to change that, to build an elder-friendly community that will meet the changing needs of older adults on the Key Peninsula. The group seeks to gather information on the priorities of the community, which will help direct a plan of action.

KP residents ages 50 and over are asked to fill out an Elder Needs Assessment survey form before July 15. The forms are available at Cost Less Pharmacy in Wauna, the New Brookside Restaurant, the Key Center Library, Sunnycrest Nursery, Sound Credit Union, the Angel Guild, Key Peninsula Health Center, the Historical Society Museum in Vaughn, Key Peninsula Lutheran Church, Lakebay Community Church, Key Peninsula Community Services in Home, and Longbranch Community Church. A minimum of 300 surveys is necessary to give insight on the priorities of the community. For information, call Edie Morgan at 884-3920.

Lakebay woman elected to state PTA

Kari Wilkinson of Lakebay was recently elected Washington State PTA Region 10 director, which covers a portion of Pierce County and consists of Clover Park, Peninsula, Steilacoom Historical, Tacoma and University Place school districts.

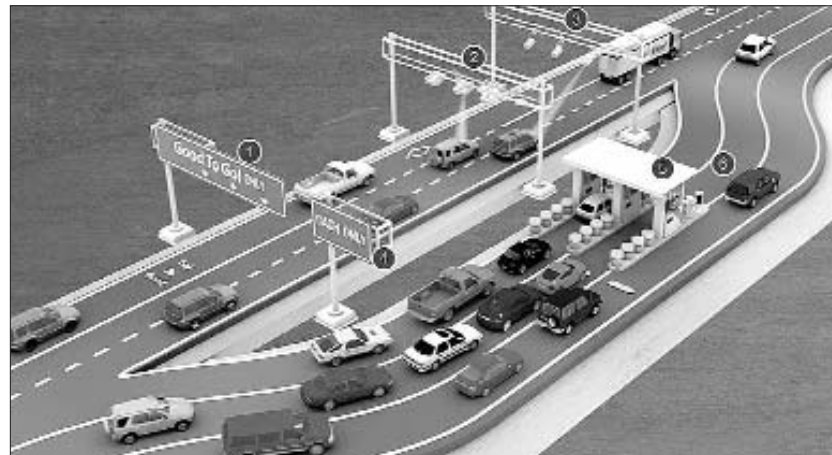
She has served as president of Evergreen Elementary PTA and Key Peninsula Middle School PTA, among others. At the state PTA level, she served on the Washington State PTA Region 10 Service Delivery Team, the Washington State PTA convention committee for the past three years, and was the co-chair of the convention committee for the annual convention in May.

Instructor receives award

Charles Cowan, an instructor in Lakebay, received the Regional Black Belt of the Year award at the sixth annual Pursuit of Excellence tournament in Lakewood. He has been teaching classes on the peninsula for two years and has several students approaching their black belt. He and his seven students took home a variety of trophies at the tournament.

Cowan is an instructor with the American Taekwondo Association. His ATA Black Belt Academy can be reached at 884-3669.

Good To Go! toll system for bridge gains momentum



An illustration of how the toll system will work.

Courtesy of WSDOT

By Christopher Britton
Special to KP News

The Washington State Department of Transportation recently launched its campaign to publicize the new electronic toll collection system, “Good To Go!” for the second Tacoma Narrows Bridge.

According to Customer Service and Marketing Manager Jessica Yasenchak, the Good To Go! information campaign is gaining momentum, with over 3,500 people responding since its April launch.

While the toll system will not officially become operational until the opening of the new bridge in July 2007, WSDOT is already promoting the early adoption of the system. Specifically, the special electronic e-sticker, which would be affixed to each commuter’s windshield.

This sticker — about the size of a library card — contains a microchip with the driver’s account information, which will be linked to the account by an antennae in the gantries overhead as the driver passes through the toll collection area. The toll will be automatically deducted from the driver’s prepaid account. These accounts may be set up by the driver as needed, or the Good To Go! customer service department can help users establish an automatic replenishment, in which additional funds are added to their prepaid account whenever the equivalent of three trips are left on the balance.

According to WSDOT’s Website, the actual toll amount — which is intended to pay off the bonds used for the construction of the bridge and its subsequent operation and maintenance — will not be determined by the Washington State Transportation Commission until later this year. While initial assumptions are that it is expected to be \$3 for the first

year, the commission is considering a possible provision for a reduced toll for Good To Go! users, officials said.

Those who elect not to use the e-sticker must pay at one of the cash-only booths in the toll plaza. Violators who attempt to cross the bridge without paying the toll or without an e-sticker face stiff penalties.

While WSDOT is still ironing out the details of the new system, officials said it is designed to save commuters time. Just how much is still uncertain, but based on a 2002 Traffic and Revenue study compiled by Wilber Smith & Associates, the projected amount of east-bound traffic over the second Narrows bridge will be approximately 42,000 commuters per day.

“WSDOT hopes to have at least 50 percent of that made up of Good To Go! commuters,” Yasenchak said. “The reason being that the more people we have paying manually, the greater risk for traffic congestion on SR-16.”

In addition to the time savings gained by not having to stop to pay the toll, other benefits touted by the WSDOT include less stress, more convenience and safer travel.

Yasenchak states that there is another reason for commuters to adopt the Good To Go! e-sticker early: As an added incentive, the e-stickers will initially be distributed at no charge. The e-stickers cost WSDOT \$10 each. After an undisclosed date, WSDOT may pass the \$10 cost to Good To Go! customers.

For more information or to apply for the Good To Go! e-stickers, visit wsdot.wa.gov/goodtogo, call 1-866-936-8246, or mail a request for more information to: Good To Go! Washington State Department of Transportation, 3214 50th Street Ct. NW, Suite 302, Gig Harbor, WA 98335-8589.